

HOUSEFULL 5
Original release: **2010**

The comedy series is one of the longest-running ones. In its fifth iteration, regulars Akshay Kumar, Riteish Deshmukh and Chunky Pandey return. Producer Sajid Nadiadwala opts for a more-the-merrier approach, with Abhishek Bachchan, Sanjay Dutt, Jackie Shroff, Nana Patekar, Shreyas Talpade joining the joyride (above)



DHADAK 2
Original release: **2018**

National crush Triptii Dimri and *Gully Boy* star Sidhant Chaturvedi feature in part 2 of the Dharma franchise. "It isn't a direct sequel but a new story that carries forward the essence of intense emotions," says Apoorva Mehta, CEO of Dharma



BORDER 2
Original release: **1997**

Twenty-eight years is a long time to revisit a beloved war drama, but given the 'josh' for the genre, it makes sense. Sunny Deol is back and joined in battle by Varun Dhawan (above, 2nd from left), Diljit Dosanjh, Ahan Shetty among others

pandemic, the idea that if a film stars a particular actor it must be worth the money, has weakened," says Kapoor, adding that only Shah Rukh Khan and Ranbir Kapoor are exceptions. Amidst the waning influence of actors and a crowded landscape of entertainment choices, a franchise offers familiarity. "They come pre-marketed, via the performance of previous editions," he notes. Case in point being Maddock's horror comedy smash hits *Stree 2* and *Munjya*, which, in turn, are expected to benefit other horror comedies like *Thama* and *Shakti Shalini* expected to release this year.

For studios, it's a win-win situation. "They are keen on building franchises because star fees continue to go up despite the box office being unstable," says Kapoor. "This incentivises a producer to invest in long-term IP [intellectual property], allowing them to make films with lesser stars, and get better return on investment." But Kapoor admits that "trust" alone cannot sustain this model. Sequels "that marry originality" with trust are the ones that "would really work".

THE FLIP SIDE

However, the juggernaut of franchise films has creators concerned about the direction in which Hindi cinema is headed, for cashing in on a hit formula comes at the expense of original ideas being sidelined. "The slow poison we [the industry] have been taking for a while is 'de-risk'," says writer-director Atul Sabharwal. "Originality means you have to think, take a chance and you don't know [the result]." Sequels, he notes, also come at a time when remakes themselves are dwindling as linguistic boundaries vanish and watching dubbed/ subtitled versions of southern films grows.

Some, though, are pleased with this onslaught. For publicity relation firms, marketing franchise films and sequels is easier. However, "they have to be superior to the previous one", says Prabhat Choudhary, founder of Spice, India's leading entertainment PR and marketing firm. "If not, the franchise value goes down." Even actor-producer Aamir Khan is giving it a shot with his next, *Sitaare Zameen Par*, whose title harks back to his beloved directorial debut, *Taare Zameen Par*. Choudhary, who will handle its marketing, calls it a "spiritual sequel", for there's "a similarity in theme and not at a story or granular level".

Extending an idea is also the need of the hour. "Post Covid, we are going through a crisis of faith about audiences," says Choudhary. "In such a cynical atmosphere, a franchise for which solidarity exists is something both audiences and makers like." He opines that creators should have built IPs much before, like Hollywood has done for decades. "*Chhaava* has succeeded. You can have a universe of Maratha heroes. Till they are interesting, it is okay," he says.

But sustaining interest is anything but a cakewalk. Ask Dharma CEO Apoorva Mehta. "It's about giving the audience what they want, in a way that still feels fresh," he adds. "Sequels challenge us as filmmakers to push boundaries." Even as audiences will see the likes of Ajay Devgn, Akshay Kumar and Hrithik Roshan reprise their roles, Sabharwal equates the current trend to something filmmaker Ram Gopal Varma had once told him. "He said, 'Each time you go out to make a film, you are choosing to be vulnerable. You are putting yourself at the mercy of the public'," recalls Sabharwal. "Now nobody wants to be vulnerable, it's about being smart." For now, calculated risks are bringing in the moolah. It's the thing that matters most in show business. ■